

SAT Reading and Writing Targeted Practice

20 original questions focused on grammar accuracy, evidence discipline, and harder-module traps

Recommended use	Complete the questions in 24 minutes. Mark any item that takes more than 90 seconds. Review every miss by naming the rule or trap.
Score guide	17–20: strong control 14–16: review misses 10–13: repeat the relevant flashcards below 10: slow down and study the explanation section

1. Sentence boundaries

Marine biologist Ayana Lee tracked the reef for six years ____ the coral population remained stable despite two unusually warm summers.

- A) years, the
- B) years; the
- C) years: and the
- D) years the

2. Colon

The archive contains one item that changed historians' understanding of the expedition ____ the navigator's original map.

- A) expedition,
- B) expedition;
- C) expedition:
- D) expedition and

3. Paired punctuation

The new telescope ____ which was assembled over four years ____ began collecting data in May.

- A) , which was assembled over four years,
- B) ; which was assembled over four years,
- C) : which was assembled over four years;
- D) which was assembled over four years

4. Subject-verb agreement

The collection of letters from several nineteenth-century poets ____ in a climate-controlled room.

- A) are stored
- B) have been stored
- C) is stored
- D) store

5. Modifiers

After reviewing the satellite images, ____

- A) the coastline's changes became obvious to Priya.
- B) Priya identified three areas of rapid erosion.
- C) three areas of rapid erosion were identified.
- D) the report described changes to the coastline.

6. Verb tense

By the time the museum opened its new wing in 2024, curators ___ more than 600 objects for display.

- A) select
- B) selected
- C) had selected
- D) will select

7. Parallel structure

The internship required students to catalog specimens, enter field notes, and ___ weekly summaries.

- A) writing
- B) wrote
- C) write
- D) to have written

8. Possessives

The two researchers compared ___ interpretations of the same inscription.

- A) the researcher's
- B) the researchers
- C) the researchers'
- D) the researchers's

9. Transitions

The first trial produced no measurable change. ___ the research team adjusted the dosage before beginning the second trial.

- A) Similarly,
- B) Consequently,
- C) For example,
- D) Meanwhile,

10. Rhetorical synthesis

A student wants to emphasize a similarity between two buildings. Notes: Building A opened in 1928 and uses limestone. Building B opened in 1974 and uses limestone. Both now house public libraries. Which choice best accomplishes the goal?

- A) Building A opened decades before Building B.
- B) Although they opened in different years, both buildings use limestone and now house public libraries.
- C) Building B opened in 1974 and now houses a public library.
- D) Building A, which opened in 1928, uses limestone.

11. Inference

In a greenhouse study, tomato plants receiving Treatment Q produced 12% more fruit than untreated plants. The study did not measure flavor or nutritional content. Which conclusion is best supported?

- A) Treatment Q improves every aspect of tomato quality.
- B) Treatment Q may increase tomato yield under the study conditions.
- C) Treatment Q is necessary for tomatoes to produce fruit.
- D) Treatment Q causes tomatoes to taste better.

12. Command of evidence

Researchers claim that shade reduces water loss in young maple trees. Which finding would most directly support the claim?

- A) Shaded and unshaded trees had similar heights.
- B) Shaded trees lost less water per day than comparable unshaded trees.
- C) Some shaded trees grew near older trees.
- D) Unshaded trees received more sunlight.

13. Data interpretation

A study recorded average weekly visits to three park areas: Meadow 42, Lake 67, Trail 51. Which statement accurately describes the data?

- A) The Trail received the most visits.
- B) The Lake received 16 more visits than the Trail.
- C) The Meadow and Trail together received fewer visits than the Lake.
- D) The Meadow received 25 more visits than the Lake.

14. Words in context

The later discovery did not refute the earlier theory; instead, it ___ the theory by showing that it applied under a wider range of conditions.

- A) undermined
- B) obscured
- C) strengthened
- D) anticipated

15. Function and purpose

A paragraph first describes a theory that city noise drives birds away. It then states, "Yet several species nested successfully beside the busiest intersections." What is the function of the quoted sentence?

- A) It defines city noise.
- B) It provides evidence that complicates the theory.
- C) It summarizes how birds build nests.
- D) It explains why intersections are busy.

16. Two-text relationship

Text 1 argues that remote work always increases productivity. Text 2 reports gains for some tasks but declines for tasks requiring rapid collaboration. How would Text 2 most likely respond to Text 1?

- A) It would fully agree with Text 1.
- B) It would reject all productivity research.
- C) It would qualify Text 1's broad claim.
- D) It would discuss an unrelated topic.

17. Scope

A survey of 120 students at one high school found that most preferred later start times. Which conclusion is best supported?

- A) All teenagers prefer later start times.
- B) Most students everywhere prefer later start times.
- C) Most surveyed students at that school preferred later start times.
- D) Later start times improve every student's grades.

18. Correlation and causation

A city found that neighborhoods with more trees also had lower summer temperatures. Which statement is justified?

- A) The data prove that planting trees alone caused every temperature difference.
- B) Tree cover was associated with lower summer temperatures in the observed neighborhoods.
- C) Lower temperatures caused residents to plant trees.
- D) Every neighborhood without trees had identical temperatures.

19. Main idea

A passage explains that a newly digitized archive gives scholars faster access to rare letters but notes that damaged pages remain difficult to interpret. Which choice best states the main idea?

- A) Digitization has solved every problem involving rare letters.
- B) The archive improves access while leaving some interpretation challenges unresolved.
- C) Damaged pages should be removed from archives.
- D) Scholars no longer need original documents.

20. Logical completion

A researcher predicted that increasing light would increase algae growth. In the experiment, light increased, but algae growth stayed unchanged. The result most directly ____

- A) proves that algae never respond to light.
- B) supports the prediction completely.
- C) weakens the prediction under the tested conditions.
- D) shows that the light level decreased.

Answer Key and Explanations

For each miss, write the rule or trap in your own words before moving on.

1. B | Sentence boundaries

Both sides are complete sentences. A semicolon can join them; a comma alone cannot.

2. C | Colon

The words before the blank form a complete sentence, and the map explains the “one item.”

3. A | Paired punctuation

The nonessential interruption needs matching commas. Removing it leaves a complete base sentence.

4. C | Subject-verb agreement

The subject is singular: “collection.” The plural nouns inside the prepositional phrase do not control the verb.

5. B | Modifiers

Priya reviewed the images, so “Priya” must immediately follow the introductory modifier.

6. C | Verb tense

The selecting happened before another past event, so past perfect (“had selected”) fits the timeline.

7. C | Parallel structure

The series uses parallel base verbs after “to”: catalog, enter, and write.

8. C | Possessives

The interpretations belong to two researchers, so the plural possessive is “researchers’.”

9. B | Transitions

The dosage adjustment occurred as a result of the first trial, so a cause-result transition is needed.

10. B | Rhetorical synthesis

The goal asks for similarity. Choice B explicitly states two shared features.

11. B | Inference

Choice B makes a cautious claim limited to yield and the study conditions. The other choices add unsupported claims.

12. B | Command of evidence

The claim concerns water loss. Choice B directly compares water loss in shaded and unshaded trees.

13. B | Data interpretation

67 minus 51 equals 16. The other comparisons misread the values.

14. C | Words in context

The discovery showed broader applicability, so it strengthened the theory.

15. B | Function and purpose

The sentence presents a result that does not fit neatly with the theory, so it complicates it.

16. C | Two-text relationship

Text 2 introduces conditions and exceptions, so it narrows or qualifies Text 1's absolute claim.

17. C | Scope

Choice C stays within the surveyed group. The other choices broaden the population or add an unmeasured outcome.

18. B | Correlation and causation

The observation establishes an association, not a proven causal mechanism.

19. B | Main idea

Choice B captures both the benefit and the limitation. The others exaggerate or add claims.

20. C | Logical completion

The predicted outcome did not occur. The cautious conclusion is that the result weakens the prediction under those conditions.

Final review: Which three rules or traps caused your misses? Review those cards again before Saturday.